

Labelling Theory and the Construction of “Communist” Identities: The Case of the Jeju 4.3 Incident



The Jeju 4.3 Incident (1947–1954) remains one of the most controversial and traumatic events in modern Korean history. While it began as a complex uprising rooted in political, social, and economic grievances, it was subsequently framed by the South Korean state as a “communist rebellion.” This labelling had profound consequences: it justified state violence, shaped public perception, and erased the identities of thousands of victims. Using labelling theory, this essay argues that the construction of “communist” identities during the Jeju 4.3 Incident was not simply descriptive but actively produced a social reality that enabled mass violence and long-term suppression of truth.

Labelling Theory: A Framework

Labelling theory, developed in sociology, suggests that deviance is not inherent in an act but is socially constructed through labels imposed by authorities. Once individuals or groups are labelled (e.g., “criminal” or “communist”), this label shapes how others perceive them and how institutions treat them. Importantly, labels can become self-fulfilling and justify unequal or violent treatment.

In the context of Jeju 4.3, the label “communist” functioned as a powerful political tool. It transformed a diverse population—many of whom were civilians—into perceived enemies of the state.

Historical Context and the Emergence of Labels

Following the end of Japanese colonial rule in 1945, Korea was divided along ideological lines during the early Cold War. Jeju Island became a site of tension, with widespread dissatisfaction toward the U.S. military government and upcoming elections. While leftist groups were indeed active, the situation was far more complex than a simple ideological uprising.

However, the South Korean government and allied forces framed the entire event as a “communist insurgency.” This narrative reduced the complexity of local grievances into a single ideological category. According to historical research, tens of thousands of people were killed during the suppression, with government forces responsible for the majority of civilian deaths.

This shows that the label “communist” was applied broadly, often without distinction between armed rebels and ordinary civilians.



「4.3」투쟁이 1차 마
무리된 49년 4월9일 주
承晚대통령이 제주 현지에
내려가 경찰진압의 신봉에
성년(20대)대 장병들을 격
려하고 있다.



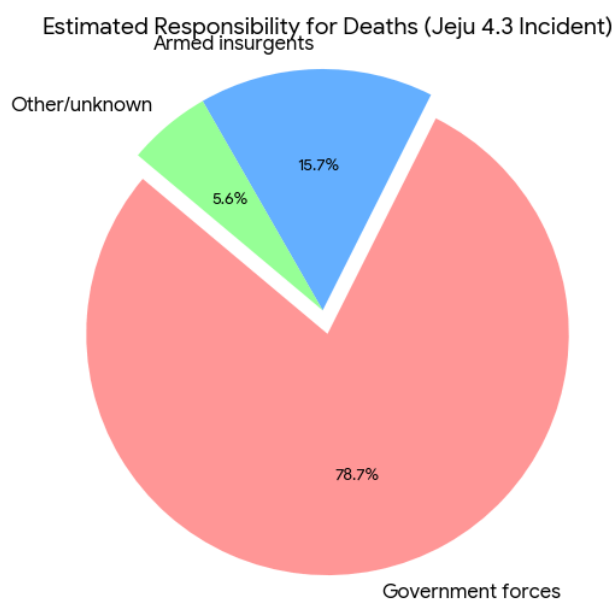
「4.3」에 가담한 혐의로
체포된 주민들이 한데 묶인
채 경마대에 의해 끌려나
고 있다. 20대 청년의 경우
노상과 부자의 모습이 보
인다.

Institutionalisation of Labels and Everyday Control

Another critical aspect of labelling in the Jeju 4.3 Incident is how the “communist” identity became embedded within formal institutions and everyday governance, transforming it from a temporary political accusation into a long-term system of control. Rather than remaining a rhetorical tool, the label was operationalised through administrative mechanisms such as police records, residency documentation, and ideological screening processes. Under the influence of the broader Cold War climate, South Korean authorities expanded surveillance practices that categorised citizens based on perceived political loyalty. This meant that labelling extended beyond those directly involved in resistance activities to include family members, neighbours, and even entire villages. In line with labelling theory, this reflects how deviance can be constructed and maintained through institutional reinforcement, where the state not only defines who is “deviant” but also systematically reproduces that identity across

generations. For many Jeju residents, being associated with the label “communist” resulted in restricted access to education, employment, and social mobility, effectively embedding inequality into the structure of society. Schools, workplaces, and local administrations became sites where these labels were quietly enforced, often without formal acknowledgement but with significant consequences. Furthermore, the bureaucratisation of labelling contributed to its persistence, as records and classifications were rarely challenged or revised, even decades after the initial events. This created a form of “archival stigma,” where individuals remained marked by past accusations regardless of changing political conditions. At the same time, the normalisation of such systems led to widespread self-censorship, as individuals adapted their behaviour to avoid suspicion. This demonstrates how labelling operates not only through overt violence but also through subtle, everyday practices that regulate behaviour and maintain social order. By institutionalising the “communist” label, the state ensured that its effects would endure far beyond the immediate period of conflict, shaping identities, opportunities, and social relations in ways that were both pervasive and difficult to dismantle.

Graph: Estimated Responsibility for Deaths



This data highlights a critical contradiction: while the state labelled victims as “communists,” it was primarily state forces that carried out the killings. The label, therefore, functioned less as an accurate description and more as a justification for repression.

The Power of the “Communist” Label

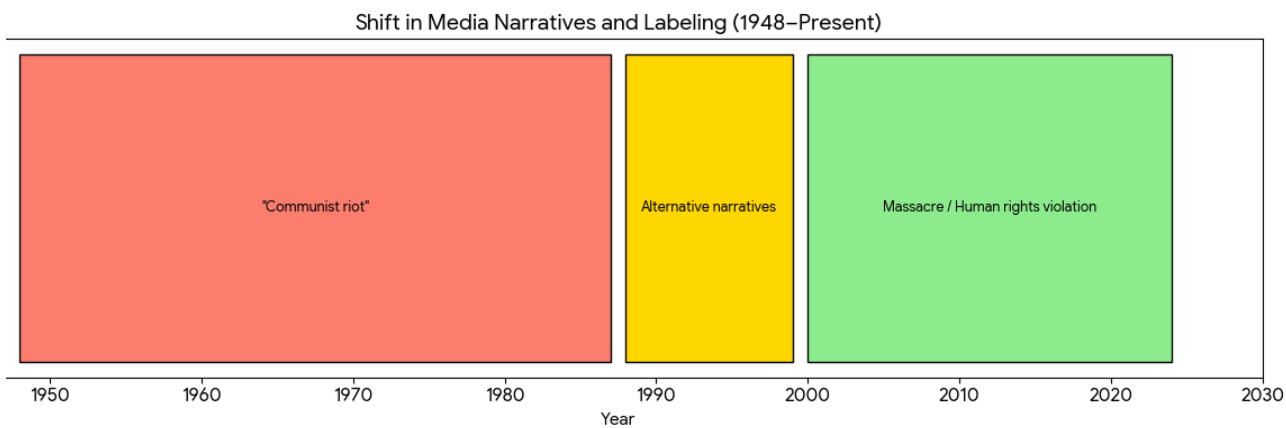
The label “communist” carried extreme weight in the Cold War context. It implied disloyalty, danger, and subversion. By applying this label to Jeju residents, the state achieved several objectives:

- 1. **Dehumanization**
Victims were no longer seen as civilians but as enemies. This made violence against them more acceptable. The treatment of bodies—such as disposal or concealment—further reflects this dehumanisation and the attempt to erase identities.
- 2. **Legitimisation of Violence**
Labelling the uprising as communist justified military suppression. It framed violence as necessary for national security rather than as human rights violations.
- 3. **Silencing and Fear**
For decades, discussing the incident was prohibited. Victims’ families remained silent out of fear of being associated with “communism.” The massacre was hidden from public knowledge for nearly 50 years.

Evidence of Labelling in Media and Memory

The persistence of labellinis is evident in media representations. Until the late 1980s, newspapers consistently described the event as a “communist riot,” reinforcing the state narrative.

Timeline of Media Narratives



This shift demonstrates how labels are not fixed but can change over time as political contexts evolve. However, the earlier label had already caused lasting damage by shaping collective memory.

Social Consequences of Labelling

The labelling of Jeju residents as “communists” had long-term social consequences:

1. **Stigmatisation of Survivors**

Families of victims were marginalised and discriminated against. Being associated with the incident could limit education and employment opportunities.

2. **Collective Silence and Trauma**

The fear of being labelled prevented open discussion, leading to what scholars describe as intergenerational trauma. The silence itself became a continuation of violence.

3. **Distortion of Historical Truth**

By controlling the narrative, the state shaped how history was understood. The incident was not officially investigated until decades later.

Re-evaluation and the Deconstruction of Labels

With democratisation in South Korea after 1987, the dominant narrative began to change. A truth commission established in 2000 investigated the events and recognised the suffering of victims.

This process represents an attempt to deconstruct the label of “communist” and restore the identities of those affected. Jeju has since been reframed as a symbol of peace and reconciliation rather than rebellion.

However, the legacy of labelling persists. Competing interpretations—such as those emphasising the role of communist insurgents—continue to influence political debates today.

Conclusion

The Jeju 4.3 Incident demonstrates the powerful role of labelling in shaping historical events. Through the application of labelling theory, it becomes clear that the term “communist” was not merely descriptive but actively constructed a social reality. It justified violence, erased individual identities, and silenced survivors for decades.

Ultimately, the re-evaluation of the incident in recent decades shows that labels can be challenged and redefined. However, the long-lasting effects of the original label highlight the dangers of allowing political narratives to define human identities. The case of Jeju 4.3 serves as a reminder that labels are not neutral—they carry the power to shape lives, histories, and collective memory.

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